Merchant Fieldwork Instruments & Concept Cards

Interview forms • observation records • concept cards • consent stub • analyst coding • field sign-off

19 October 2026 • Version 1.0 for pre-joining research • Confidential working draft

USE STATUS	INSTRUCTION
Current status	Draft only. No participant recruited; no field validation has occurred.
Authority	Use only following signed institutional research approval and Legal/CISO-approved adaptations.
Translation	English master; translation/back-translation and local cultural review must occur before field use.
Privacy	Do not record identifiable payment/customer data. Use pseudonymous IDs; consent separates participation, audio and photos.

Form 0 — Short recruitment screen (do not store contact details here)

☐ Study ID: _____ Date: _____ Interviewer code: _____ Recruitment route: _____

☐ Merchant setting (select): market stall / micro retail / service / hospitality / other _____

☐ Geography class: Addis / secondary city / peri-urban / rural (approved study site code only) _____

☐ Payment channel self-report: cash only / business wallet-QR / personal wallet-transfer / POS-card / mixed / unknown

☐ Trading activity: daily / weekly / seasonal. Approx years operating: <1 / 1–3 / 4–10 / >10 / prefer not to say

☐ Device access: basic / smartphone / shared smartphone / none / uncertain. Connectivity: often / sometimes / rare

☐ Qualitative balancing fields where lawfully permitted: self-described owner gender (optional) / segment / accessibility needs (optional)

☐ Exclude: unwilling to consent; interview would expose active customer transactions; researcher conflict or sponsor pressure.

Form 1 — Consent script (template only; legal localisation required)

“We are studying how shops and services handle payments, including cash and digital payments, and which problems are difficult. This discussion is voluntary. It is not a PSS product launch or offer, and participation will not affect any banking service. We do not need your name, payment credentials, customers’ details or exact transactions. You may skip questions or stop at any time. Notes will be coded using a study ID and handled under the approved research policy. Do you agree to participate?”

Participation: Yes / No | Separate permission to observe non-sensitive steps: Yes / No | Audio: Yes / No | Photos: Yes / No (default no)

Consent version: _____ language: _____ interviewer signature: _____ withdrawal/contact route defined by institutional policy: _____

Do not administer without approved participant information sheet, lawful basis, data controller/processor assignment, retention notice and language review.

Form 2 — Unprompted merchant interview (core questions)

ID	QUESTION	NEUTRAL PROBE / RESTRICTION
Q01	Tell me about a typical busy day. Which payments are easiest and which are hardest?	Never start by mentioning PSS or a proposed app.
Q02	In your last three customer sales, how was payment made?	Do not ask for identities or amounts if identifiable.
Q03	When a customer sends you money, how do you know it arrived?	Probe app status/SMS/customer phone/ledger.
Q04	How do you distinguish a customer payment from a personal transfer?	Probe business vs personal account separately.
Q05	When payment status is unclear, what exactly do you do?	Probe support, refund, reversals, time lost.
Q06	At day close, how do you reconcile payments with sales?	Ask for a generic walkthrough, not real screen.
Q07	Which digital tools, bank or wallet products do you already use?	What is good enough already? Why?
Q08	Have you refused a digital payment? Why?	Ask network, customer demand, trust and costs.
Q09	What is the most common payment problem you can remember in the past month?	Separate frequency from severity.
Q10	Have you contacted a bank or wallet for payment help? What happened?	Probe time and satisfaction; do not collect staff names.
Q11	Who should help you when a customer says “I paid” but you cannot confirm it?	Keep possible operator roles neutral.
Q12	Would a different record-keeping or proof-of-payment workflow matter? Why or why not?	Do not promise credit, instant settlement or guarantees.
Q13	What phone and connection conditions do you typically have?	Do not record IMEI, phone numbers or exact location.
Q14	Which fees are visible today and how do they affect payment choice?	Distinguish consumer, merchant, bank, informal charges.
Q15	What is one improvement you would choose if you could fix only one problem?	Capture words verbatim where consent permits.

Form 3 — Contextual observation / journey map

STEP	OBSERVE IN A GENERIC OR REHEARSED SCENARIO	CAPTURE
1	Customer offers a payment method	Chosen method; who initiates and what instructions appear
2	Merchant communicates merchant identifier / payment destination	Personal vs merchant acceptance identity; risk of confusion
3	Merchant expects confirmation	Typical wait and trust cue; never expose live payment data
4	Ambiguous / failed status in a fictional scenario	Actions, fallback, customer handling, escalation
5	Day-end reconciliation with invented amounts and customer codes	Time to identify duplicates/missing payments and balances
6	Request for support through an illustrated menu	Understandability, relevance and acceptable response route

Walkthrough observation record: Study ID _____; Scenario ID _____; Completed independently Yes/No/With help; elapsed time _____; misunderstanding _____; existing workaround _____; quote _____; observer _____.

Form 4 — Balanced concept cards

A | Payment status & exceptions

A fictional shop sees a list of fictional payments. One is confirmed, one pending and one needs checking. There is a "report a problem" option through the sponsoring bank.

NON-PRODUCTION TASK What does "pending" mean? Which next action is safest?

REALISTIC ALTERNATIVE Could an existing bank/telebirr statement already solve it?

B | Multi-channel daily totals

A fictional shop sees a single daily total split by eligible channels with references that do not expose payer-sensitive details.

NON-PRODUCTION TASK Can the respondent detect a duplicate in a test row?

REALISTIC ALTERNATIVE Does merchant actually need more than one channel?

C | Eligible-phone card acceptance

A hypothetical phone-based acceptance interface is available only where compatible and properly authorised. This is an illustrated concept, not PSS Pay product demonstration.

NON-PRODUCTION TASK Does merchant understand the device/customer requirements?

REALISTIC ALTERNATIVE Would QR, cash or existing POS be simpler?

D | Improve current practice

Existing payment app, training and support remain; no new product. A short tip sheet clarifies what to do with missing payment messages.

NON-PRODUCTION TASK Does the respondent prefer this? Why?

REALISTIC ALTERNATIVE What non-product adjustment solves the problem?

Order rotation: Study ID ending in 0/4/8 = A,B,C,D; 1/5/9 = B,C,D,A; 2/6 = C,D,A,B; 3/7 = D,A,B,C. Record exposure order; randomised allocation may replace this if approved by methodology owner.

Form 5 — Concept evaluation (complete for all A–D)

FIELD	RESPONSE / NOTE
Study ID / order / card	_____
Explain-back: "What does it do?"	_____
Relevance: 1 none – 5 critical	____ Reason: _____
Ease of understanding: 1–5	____ Misunderstanding: _____
Task result: independent / helped / unsuccessful	____ Time (sec): _____ Observed: _____
Existing alternative; why insufficient	_____
Barriers / prerequisites	_____
Preferred provider and payer	_____
Rank after all four cards	A __ B __ C __ D __
Strongest contradiction to our hypothesis	_____

Form 6 — Rapid coding guide (first-pass, non-exclusive tags)

CODE	DESCRIPTION / DECISION NOTE
PAIN-STATUS	Cannot tell finality of customer payment; note whether actual vs perceived failure
PAIN-RECON	Daily closing, duplicates, mismatches, missing references

CODE	DESCRIPTION / DECISION NOTE
PAIN-SUPPORT	Provider/bank contact, escalation, refund/chargeback confusion
PAIN-NET	Connectivity, battery, device compatibility
PAIN-TRUST	Fraud concern, acceptance uncertainty, customer dispute
PAIN-COST	Direct fees, opportunity/time cost, required hardware
VALUE-OPERATE	Positive value from payment status / exception workflow
VALUE-CONNECT	Positive value from permitted multi-channel reporting
VALUE-ACCEPT	Positive value from eligible phone-based acceptance
STATUS-QUO	Existing tools already solve the problem
NEGATIVE-CASE	Explicit rejection / contrary evidence / no unmet need

Form 7 — Daily interviewer log and quality review

☐ Session count planned / completed / declined: _____ / _____ / _____

☐ Approved site code / language / interviewer: _____ / _____ / _____

☐ Consent complete: Yes / No; any disallowed personal data recorded: No / Incident escalated

☐ Sampling gaps remaining (cash-only, personal-account, rural etc.): _____

☐ New themes vs yesterday; strong disconfirming cases: _____

☐ Bias issue or change to question order: _____

☐ Files stored in approved location: _____; supervisor review date: _____

Form 8 — Go / re-scope / stop research summary

Sample sizes and setting: _____; top documented jobs-to-be-done: _____; most meaningful counterevidence: _____; concept comparison: _____; triangulation with V03 bank need: _____; technical/legal blockers: _____; recommended disposition: further research / amend requirements / stop new merchant product; reviewer: _____.

Annex — Sources and fieldworker reading

REF	READ BEFORE FIELDWORK
R01	NBE — Draft National Digital Payments Strategy, 2026–2030 https://nbe.gov.et/ndps/
R02	DFS Lab / Merchant Payments Observatory — Ethiopia Wave 1 research publications, April 2026 https://mpo.dfslab.net/research.html
R03	World Bank — Global Findex 2025, Ethiopia 2024 microdata https://microdata.worldbank.org/catalog/7901/data-dictionary/F1
R04	GSMA — What Will It Take to Scale Merchant Payments? January 2026 https://www.gsma.com/solutions-and-impact/connectivity-for-good/mobile-for-development/gsma_resources/what-will-it-take-to-scale-merchant-payments-harnessing-the-digital-opportunity/
R05	CGAP — Merchant Payments: Adding Value for Merchants, 2019 https://www.cgap.org/research/publication/merchant-payments-adding-value-for-merchants
R06	CGAP — Choosing a Profit Strategy for Merchant Payments, 2019 https://www.cgap.org/research/publication/choosing-profit-strategy-for-merchant-payments
R07	PCI SSC — Mobile Payments on COTS (MPoC) https://www.pcisecuritystandards.org/standards/mobile-payments-on-cots-mpoc/